After discovering that state hiring policies sometimes unintentionally discriminated against minorities, I devoted a lot of time to bringing more blacks and Hispanics into important jobs in the state government. Nevertheless, a myth persisted that I was insensitive to minorities. Once I got a call from several black leaders from the San Francisco Bay Area who said they wanted to talk to me about my "treatment of blacks."

When they arrived in my office, it was clear what was on their minds; there was a look of hostility on their faces and it was evident they were just itching to attack me as a racist. And so, I said:

"Look, are you aware that I've appointed more blacks to executive and policy-making positions in the state government than all the previous governors of California put together?"

One said, "Yes, but why aren't you out there telling people about it? How come you haven't bragged about it?"

Well, I was amazed by the question. "In appointing these people, I just was doing what I thought was right," I said. "I think it would have been cheap politics if I'd gone out and started singing a song about it. Besides, they were the best people for the job; I didn't appoint them just because they were blacks. . . ."

With that, the whole atmosphere of the meeting changed. They said they thought I had been quiet about it because I was fearful of angering my more conservative white supporters.

When we left the room, we left literally with our arms around each other.

As I found myself enjoying my job more, Nancy, as always, gave me a lot of support, but not in the way some of my critics have claimed over the years. She's been subjected to a bum rap.